Congress chances because only the rich complained about price rise, the poor had food security. ‘I really don’t know which planet Rahul is living on,’ the analyst told me.

Interestingly, Rahul had spoken a very different language after the party’s debacle in the December 2013 assembly elections. Then, he had strode defiantly to the Congress headquarters and told the waiting media, ‘I am going to transform the Congress organization and I will do it in ways you cannot even imagine.’ Now, just two months later, he was claiming to be just a ‘cog in the wheel’. Far from being transformed, the Congress and its leadership was already looking battle weary.

When we broadcast our final election tracker towards the end of March, the NDA figure was pushing towards the 260-seat mark—272-plus was now firmly in sight. The Congress was in total disarray, slipping further to under eighty seats. Aware that this election was theirs to be won, the BJP decided to go for the kill. The perfume of victory was in the air.

~

After offering prayers at the Vaishno Devi shrine, Narendra Modi began his final march towards Delhi with a Bharat Vijay rally in Jammu on 26 March. Modi had already addressed more than 200 rallies since becoming BJP’s prime ministerial candidate in September.

Now, with the first voting day less than two weeks away, Modi decided to take his campaign to another level. Over the next seven weeks, he would address as many as 185 rallies spread across 295 constituencies, often doing four, at times even six, in a single day. An *India Today* report claimed that by the end, Modi would have travelled 300,000 kilometres, or seven times the Earth’s equatorial circumference.

Organizing the logistics for the rallies was a team of about fifty people at the party’s headquarters in Delhi, led by party MP Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi. It was a gargantuan exercise, ensuring, for example, that the BJP’s privately hired multi-camera teams were present at each major location to uplink a feed that could be carried by all news channels. The camera teams were told